

Tourism



"To attract more tourists to the 'Tamilnadu Hotel' the Hon'ble Chief Minister Dr. Kalaingar Karunanidhi launched the 'Platinum Card' and 'Gold Card' on behalf of the Tamilnadu Tourism Department. Many dignitaries from the department were present during the launch."

The Government of Tamilnadu has formed a new Department of "Tourism and Culture" in order to give an impetus for the growth of Tourism and Culture.

The Government is determined to promote private partnership in promoting tourism and identified 18 places as Less Known Tourist destinations. A Subsidy Scheme has been introduced in order to encourage private entrepreneurs to start Tourism Projects in the Less Known Tourist destinations. Under this scheme 10% of total cost of the project (excluding land cost) is granted as subsidy, subject to a maximum of Rupees One Crore. Similarly, a subsidy scheme for starting Heritage Hotels converting heritage buildings has been introduced.

For promoting Rural Tourism a sum of Rs. 473.35 lakhs has been sanctioned for development of Chettinad in Sivagangai District.

An Awareness Campaign,

"விருத்தினர் போற்றுதல் விருத்தினர் போற்றுதல் நற்றமிழ் நாட்டில் சுற்றுலா போற்றுதல்"

is conducted in Chennai city and other places in the State to create tourist friendly culture among the porters, Auto/ Taxi drivers, and others having contact with tourists on their arrival at Airport/ Railway Station.

In order to augment the services of Tourist Guides, the Government have planned to train 400 educated youth as tourist guides and the training courses are conducted through Anna Institute of Management, Chennai at the following 10 centres-

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| 1. Chennai | 6. Madurai |
| 2. Mamallapuram | 7. Rameswaram |
| 3. Kancheepuram | 8. Kanniyakumari |
| 4. Tiruchirapalli | 9. Kodaikanal |
| 5. Thanjavur | 10. Udhagamandalam |

For promotion of Cultural activities, Mamallapuram Dance Festival is organized for one month during December-January every year. Besides classical dancers, rural folk artistes are participating in this festival. National Heritage Festival is celebrated at Kanniyakumari for 7 days every year. National Pilgrim Festival is also celebrated at Rameswaram every year. Summer Festival is celebrated at Udhagamandalam, Kodaikanal, Yercaud and Elagiri Hills every year.

Tamilnadu Tourism has initiated Medical Tourism as a pioneer project in association with the Indian Medical Association and Medi Tour (p) Limited. Medical Tourism Desk has been opened in the headquarters and Travel Desks have been opened in selected hospitals in Chennai City. After medical treatment, the patients coming from foreign countries and other states are visiting tourist places and have a pleasant experience.

Tamilnadu Tourism has received three National Awards from the Government of India for Best Publicity campaign, Best Rural Tourism and Best NGO in India. Tamilnadu Tourism Development Corporation (TTDC) is conducting several package tours for the visiting tourists. For one day Tirupati Tour, two Volvo buses are operated. In addition to Muttukadu Boat House, a Boat House has been inaugurated at Mudaliarkuppam and Water Scooters are hired for promotion of Adventure Tourism. Cycle Tourism has been introduced at Beach Resort Complex, Mamallapuram collaboration with TI Cycles (P) Limited.

Tamilnadu Tourism Development Corporation is organizing India Industrial Trade Fair at Island Grounds from December to February every year. In order to promote cultural activities, cultural programmes both classical and folk-dances are conducted in the Anna Auditorium on all the days. Besides, other fairs of private agencies are also organized in the Island Grounds. Education Fair has been conducted by Tamilnadu Tourism Development Corporation in Rajaji Hall premises for one week in July 2008, which was widely welcomed by all people.